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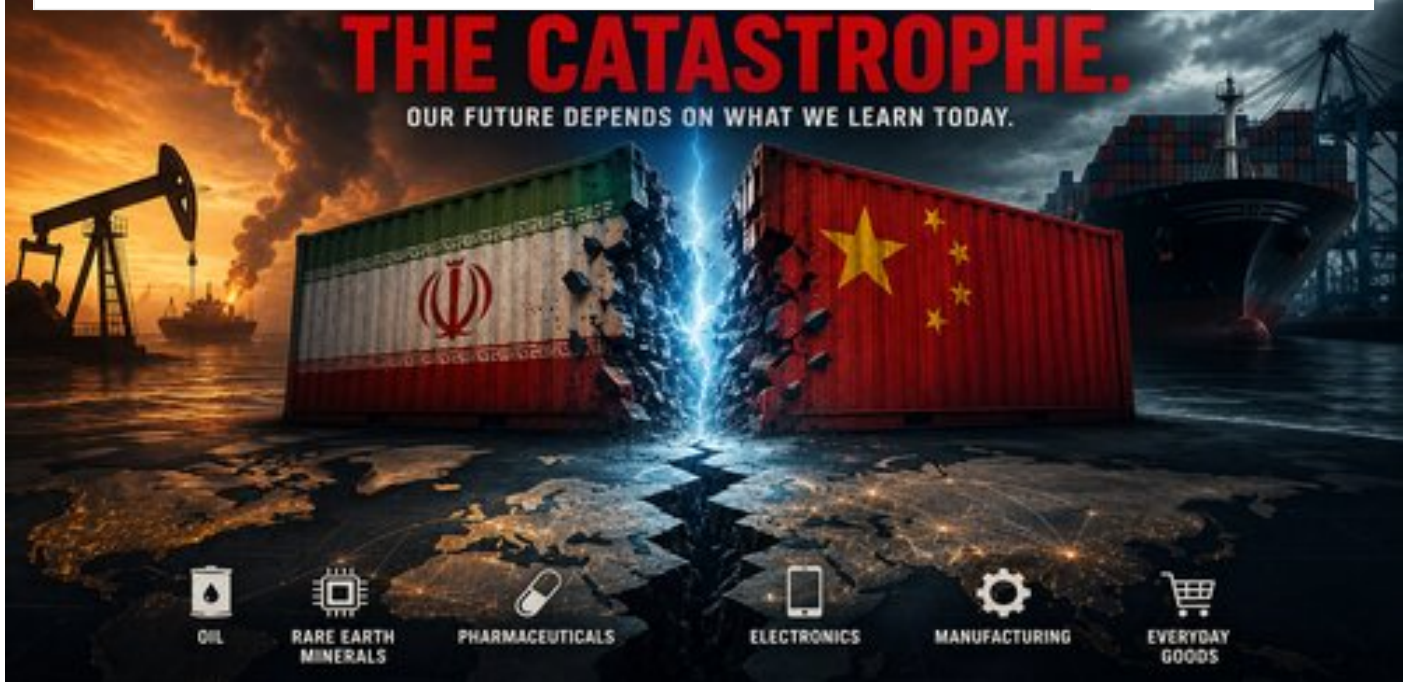
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ARTICLE

Iran Was The Warning. China Could Be The Catastrophe.



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BY PNW STAFF JUNE 29, 2026

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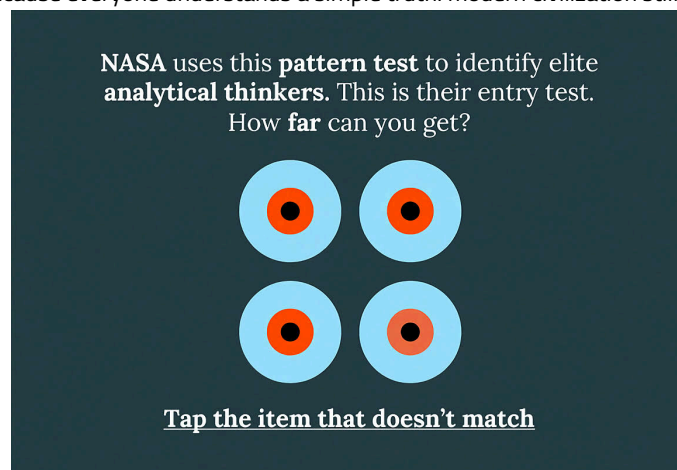
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For the past several weeks, the world's attention has been fixed on Iran.

Military strikes. Missile exchanges. A fragile ceasefire. Constant speculation about whether the Strait of Hormuz might stay open or closed. Markets have reacted nervously because everyone understands a simple truth: modern civilization still runs on energy.



For a brief moment, the world caught a glimpse of how fragile our interconnected economy really is.

But if we think Iran represents the greatest economic threat facing the West, we are looking in the wrong direction.

The conflict with Iran may ultimately be remembered as a dress rehearsal.

A confrontation with China would be an entirely different story.

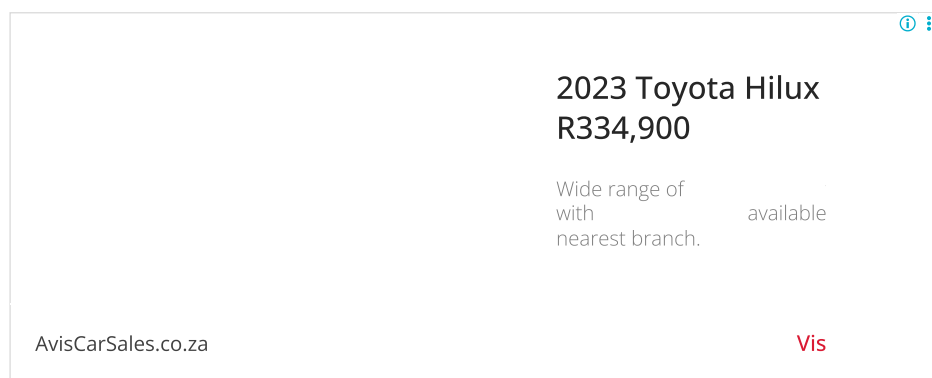
If Iran can shake the global economy by threatening the flow of oil, China possesses something arguably even more powerful--the ability to choke off the materials, products, and manufacturing that modern life depends upon every single day.



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An advertisement for the 2023 Toyota Hilux. The car is shown in a dark, sleek design. The text '2023 Toyota Hilux' is prominently displayed in white, followed by the price 'R334,900'. Below this, a smaller line of text reads 'Wide range of with nearest branch.' and 'available'. At the bottom left, the website 'AvisCarSales.co.za' is listed, and at the bottom right, the word 'Vis' is written in red.

Iran Showed Us Our Weakness

The recent Middle East crisis reminded us how dependent the global economy remains upon uninterrupted energy supplies. Roughly one-fifth of the world's oil passes through the Strait of Hormuz. Even the possibility of disruption caused oil prices to spike and governments to begin contingency planning. The recent ceasefire has reduced immediate fears, but analysts continue describing the situation as fragile, with global markets remaining sensitive to any renewed escalation.

That dependence should have been a wake-up call.

Instead, many are breathing a sigh of relief and returning to business as usual.

That would be a dangerous mistake.

Because America's dependence on China extends far beyond gasoline prices.

It reaches into nearly every aspect of daily life.

The Hidden Supply Chain We Rarely Think About

Walk through your home.

Look at your television.

Your smartphone.

Your laptop.

Kitchen appliances.

Medical devices.

Power tools.

Electric vehicles.

Children's toys.

Odds are, China was involved somewhere in their production.

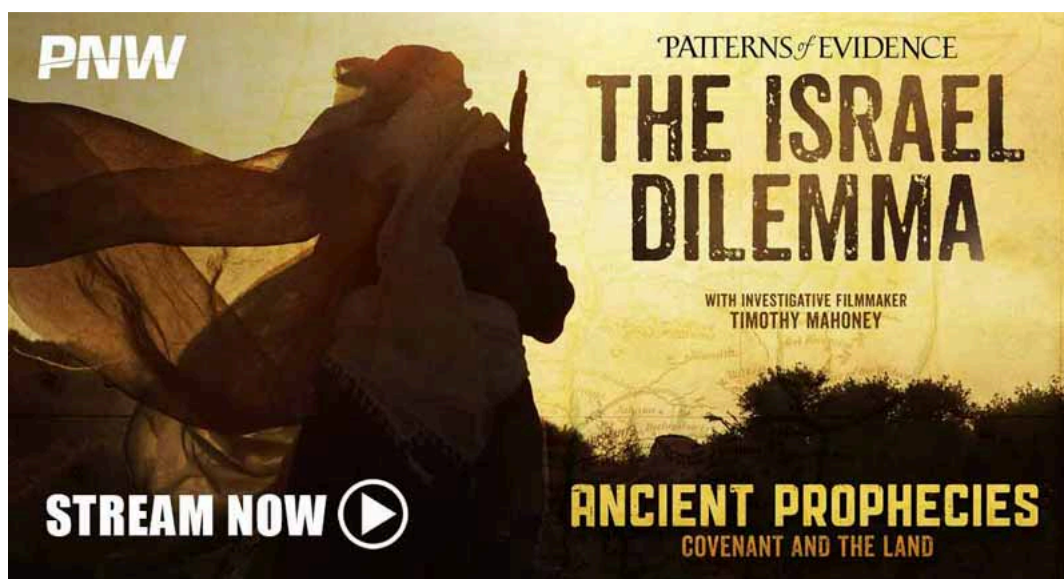
The United States has spent decades outsourcing manufacturing to lower-cost countries, with China becoming the world's factory.

What once appeared to be smart economics has quietly become a profound national security vulnerability.



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The Rare Earth Problem

Perhaps nowhere is this dependence more alarming than rare earth elements.

Despite the name, these minerals are not particularly rare.

Processing them economically is.

China controls approximately 70 percent of global rare earth mining and an even larger share of the world's refining capacity. Those materials are indispensable for everything from smartphones and electric motors to fighter jets, guided missiles, wind turbines, MRI machines, and advanced semiconductors. Recent Chinese export restrictions exposed just how vulnerable Western supply chains remain, with U.S. manufacturers reporting shortages and defense planners warning that rebuilding alternative supply chains will take years rather than months.

Think about that.

The same country viewed as America's primary strategic competitor also dominates the materials needed to build many of America's most advanced weapons.

Medicines From Abroad

The dependence extends into healthcare.

Many Americans assume pharmaceuticals are made domestically.

In reality, large portions of the world's pharmaceutical supply chain—including active pharmaceutical ingredients, precursor chemicals, and essential medical products—depend heavily on Chinese manufacturing or Chinese-controlled supply networks.

Imagine pharmacies unable to refill common prescriptions.

Hospitals delaying procedures because critical supplies never arrive.

Manufacturers shutting down because essential industrial chemicals cannot be sourced.

This is not fearmongering.

It is simple supply-chain mathematics.



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The average person rarely thinks about semiconductors, magnets, lithium processing, industrial chemicals, precision electronics, or advanced battery materials.

Until they disappear.

The COVID pandemic offered a small preview.

Remember empty store shelves?

Delayed vehicle production?

Computer shortages?

Building materials doubling in price?

Now imagine disruptions not lasting months--but potentially years.

Imagine those shortages occurring during a military confrontation rather than a public health crisis.

Iran showed us how quickly energy uncertainty can rattle financial markets.

China possesses leverage over manufacturing, electronics, telecommunications, pharmaceuticals, critical minerals, industrial machinery, consumer goods, and countless intermediate components that businesses rely upon every day.

That level of dependence creates vulnerabilities no nation should willingly accept.

Building Resilience Before Crisis

None of this means America should isolate itself from global trade.

International commerce has lifted billions from poverty and brought tremendous prosperity.

But resilience matters.

Diversification matters.

Domestic manufacturing matters.

Trusted allies matter.

Families can learn this lesson as well.

Preparedness does not require panic.



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Supporting domestic manufacturing where practical.

Learning practical skills.

Growing food if possible.

Reducing unnecessary dependence upon fragile supply chains.

Resilient families contribute to resilient nations.

The Bigger Lesson

History repeatedly teaches that civilizations often ignore vulnerabilities until crisis forces painful change.

The recent confrontation with Iran reminded us that the global economy remains astonishingly fragile.

We would be wise not to waste that lesson.

Because if a regional conflict over oil can unsettle the entire world...

Imagine what a prolonged economic confrontation with the nation that manufactures so much of what the world consumes would look like.

That would not simply mean higher gasoline prices.

It could touch nearly every shelf, every hospital, every factory, every electronics store, every pharmacy, and every home.

The current tensions with Iran should not simply make us thankful that oil continues flowing.

They should motivate us to ask a much larger question:

What happens if the world's factory suddenly stops shipping?

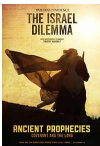
If we fail to answer that question now--while we still have time--the next geopolitical crisis could make today's headlines look like child's play.

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